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Credit - Drishti Ias

Nepal’s Climate Justice Claim: From Disaster Relief to Climate Liability

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For Prelims: Hindu Kush Himalayas , Arctic warming , **Paris Agreement** , **Loss and Damage** , **UNFCC , Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction**

For Mains: Loss and Damage Fund, adaptation finance and climate-resilient infrastructure, Common but Differentiated Responsibilities

Source: TH

Why in News?

A **rock-ice avalanche and flash flood in Nepal in August 2026** , destroyed infrastructure and wiped out around **10% of the country’s installed hydropower capacity** . The disaster sparked a debate on **climate justice and liability** , after Nepal’s Foreign Minister called for climate compensation from **major greenhouse gases (GHGs)** emitters, including the **US, China and India** .

- In response, India urged **developed countries, given their historical responsibility for GHG emissions,** to take the lead in emission reductions and provide climate technologies to developing nations.

Summary

- Nepal’s climate compensation demand highlights the gap between **low-emitting countries’ vulnerability and major emitters’ responsibility** , while the Paris Agreement’s **Article 8 limits legal claims for liability or compensation** .
- The crisis underscores the need for **Himalayan cooperation** through transboundary early-warning systems, hydrometeorological data sharing, climate finance, disaster-risk insurance and resilient hydropower infrastructure.

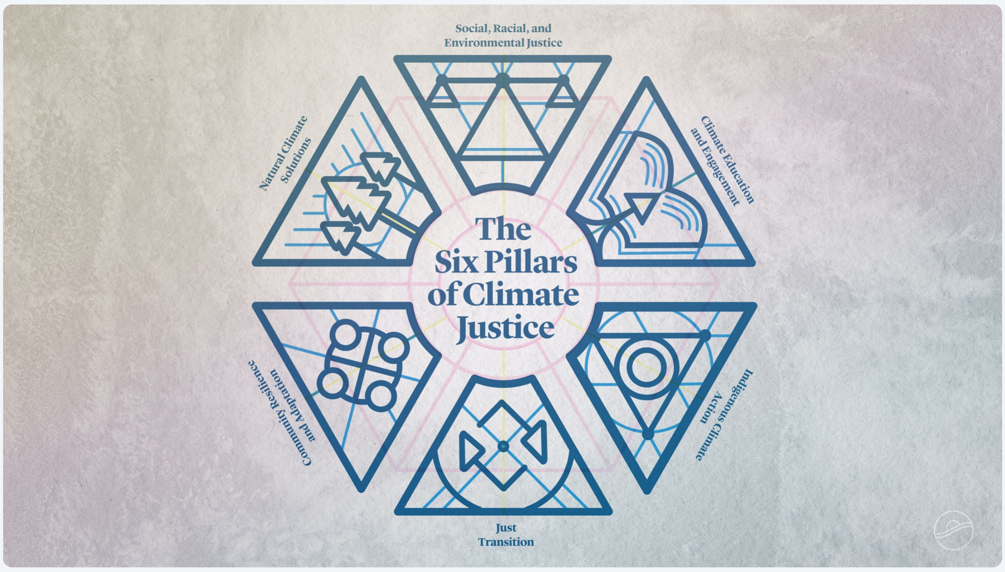
What is the Rationale Behind Nepal’s Climate

Justice and Liability Claims?

- **The "Third Pole" Paradox:** Nepal contributes a negligible **0.1%** to global GHG emissions. However, the **Hindu Kush Himalayas (HKH)** known as the "Third Pole" are experiencing **Elevation-Dependent Warming (EDW)** at nearly twice the global average, causing glaciers to melt at 10 times their historical norms.
- **Macroeconomic Crippling:** The disaster inflicted damages estimated between **USD 4 billion and USD 7 billion** , wiping out roughly **10% of Nepal's GDP.**
  - The destruction of major **Run-of-the-River (RoR) hydropower** assets forced Nepal to transition overnight from **a regional electricity exporter to an importer, crippling its strategy to offset trade deficits.**
- **The Climate-Debt Trap:** Rebuilding destroyed infrastructure requires climate-resilient engineering, which inherently escalates **capital expenditure** **(CapEx).** Without direct compensation, vulnerable nations are forced to take on commercial debt to adapt to a crisis they did not trigger.
- **Complex Cryospheric Teleconnections:** Scientific research links localized glacial destabilization to broader global systems, such as **Arctic warming, shifts in atmospheric circulation , and South Asian monsoon variability** .
  - While these teleconnections connect local disasters to global emissions, establishing direct **legal causality requires extensive data modeling.**
- **Differentiating Responsibility:** Nepal seeks to shift climate finance **from voluntary humanitarian aid to greater accountability** , arguing that vulnerable, low-emitting countries should not bear the costs of climate-induced disasters alone.
  - Its approach distinguishes between **historical responsibility** , targeting developed countries such as the **US** for their cumulative GHG emissions, and **proximate responsibility** , highlighting **China and India** as major current emitters and regional powers with greater responsibility for Himalayan climate risks and disaster recovery.

Climate Justice

- **Climate justice** recognises that climate change disproportionately affects **vulnerable communities that have contributed least to global emissions** . It seeks equitable climate action by addressing both **environmental impacts and underlying social inequalities** .



Click here to Read: Nepal Flash Floods and Vulnerability of the Himalayan Region

What are the Systemic Challenges in Establishing Climate Compensation and Legal Liability?

- **Explicit Exclusion Under International Law:** Although **Article 8 of the** Paris Agreement recognises Loss and Damage , it explicitly states that this provision **does not provide a basis for liability or compensation** .
  - Therefore, countries cannot use the UNFCCC **framework** to establish a legal claim for damages against specific emitters.
- **Structural Deficits of the Loss and Damage Fund:** The Fund for Responding to Loss and Damage (FRLD) , operationalized at COP28 , is severely undercapitalized.
  - It holds roughly USD 700 million against the multi-billion-dollar costs of single disasters. Furthermore, its pilot phase grant ceilings (USD 5 million to USD 20 million) and slow disbursement mechanisms are entirely mismatched for rapid emergency recovery.
- **Attribution Science Limitations:** Establishing legal liability requires proving that a specific disaster such as the sudden rock-ice collapse on the border would not have occurred absent **anthropogenic warming.**
  - The complex interaction between seismic activity, local geomorphology, and weather patterns makes definitive legal attribution difficult.
- **Relief as Soft Power vs. Binding Reparations:** Major powers routinely provide **emergency humanitarian relief** (deploying helicopters, rescue teams, and medical aid) as an exercise of bilateral

diplomacy.

  - However, they strictly resist institutionalizing legal frameworks that could expose them to compensatory liability.

What are the Implications for India and Regional Hydropolitics?

- **Inversion of the CBDR-RC Doctrine:** India has consistently defended the principle of **Common But Differentiated Responsibilities and Respective Capabilities (CBDR-RC)** against the Global North, arguing that developed nations must finance global climate action.
  - Nepal's regional claims invert this argument, putting India as **South Asia's largest economy and emitter** under moral pressure to assist smaller neighbors.
- **Geopolitical Bottlenecks in Power Trade:** India's policy guidelines on the **Cross-Border Trade in Electricity (CBET)** restrict the import of power generated by projects involving Chinese contractors or capital.
  - This policy directly constraints revenue streams for damaged or stalled Nepali hydropower assets, impeding fiscal self-recovery.
- **Transboundary Early Warning Vulnerabilities:** The disaster underscored systemic gaps in cross-border disaster risk reduction.
  - Despite bilateral discussions regarding **glacial lake outburst floods (GLOFs)** and hazard risks in the Tibetan Plateau, real-time hydrometeorological data sharing remains constrained by geopolitical sensitivities.
- **Shared Ecological Vulnerability:** The degradation of the Himalayan cryosphere is not a localized Nepali crisis.
  - Glacial destabilization directly threatens downstream perennial river flows in the Indo-Gangetic plain, making mountain climate resilience a shared domestic security issue for India.

Way Forward

- **Establish Automated Transboundary Telemetry:** India, China, Nepal, and Bhutan must operationalize an **open-access Himalayan early warning network.**
  - Real-time satellite radar and hydrological telemetry across the Tibetan Plateau and upper catchments are necessary to achieve **Target G of the Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction.**
- **Institute Regional Parametric Risk Pooling:** South Asia should create a regional catastrophe insurance facility (modeled after the **Caribbean Catastrophe Risk Insurance Facility)** .
  - Parametric triggers based on scientific thresholds (such as river volume surge or seismic-cryospheric shifts) ensure immediate emergency liquidity without protracted political negotiations.
- **Delink Infrastructure Recovery from Geopolitics:** Regional energy architectures, including the **BBIN (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal) initiative** , should introduce humanitarian carve-outs in power offtake agreements to allow grid-tied revenue generation from disaster-rehabilitated plants.
- **Recondition Global Climate Finance Mechanisms:** The UNFCCC must establish rapid-disbursement emergency windows within the **Loss and Damage framework** to bridge the gap between immediate humanitarian aid and long-term adaptation grants, preventing debt accumulation in vulnerable economies.

Conclusion

Nepal's intervention highlights the gap between climate vulnerability and international accountability. While existing frameworks limit legal claims for compensation, Himalayan stability requires a shift from reactive relief to institutionalised climate finance, transboundary data-sharing and resilient infrastructure cooperation.

Drishti Mains Question:

From Nepal's climate compensation demand to Himalayan disaster resilience, the emerging challenge is not merely climate mitigation but climate accountability and adaptation. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions

1. What does Article 8 of the Paris Agreement provide regarding Loss and Damage?
It recognises **Loss and Damage associated with climate change** , but explicitly states that Article 8 does **not provide a basis for liability or compensation** .

2. What is the Loss and Damage Fund (FRLD)?
Established at **COP28** , the Fund aims to provide financial support to **particularly vulnerable developing countries** facing climate-related loss and damage.

3. Why is establishing legal liability for climate disasters difficult?
It requires establishing a **direct causal link between specific emissions and a particular disaster** , which is complicated by multiple interacting climatic, geological and local factors.

4. How is Nepal's climate claim linked to CBDR-RC?
Nepal invokes **climate justice and differentiated responsibility** , arguing that countries contributing more to global emissions should bear a greater share of the costs faced by vulnerable, low-emitting nations.

5. What regional measures can strengthen Himalayan climate resilience?
Key measures include **transboundary early-warning systems, real-time hydrometeorological data sharing, regional parametric insurance, climate-resilient infrastructure and regional energy cooperation** .

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/vMhjq7PDujU**]

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Prelims

Q. The Partnership for Action on Green Economy (PAGE), a UN mechanism to assist countries transition towards greener and more inclusive economies, emerged at (2018)

(a) The Earth Summit on Sustainable Development 2002, Johannesburg.

(b) The United Nations Conference on Sustainable Development 2012, Rio de Janeiro.

(c) The United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change 2015, Paris.

(d) The World Sustainable Development Summit 2016, New Delhi.

Ans: (b)

Q. Sustainable development is described as the development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs. In this perspective, inherently the concept of sustainable development is intertwined with which of the following concepts? (2010)

(a) Social justice and empowerment

(b) Inclusive Growth

(c) Globalization

(d) Carrying capacity

Ans: (d)

Mains:

Q1. Differentiate the causes of landslides in the Himalayan region and Western Ghats. **(2021)**

Q2. How will the melting of Himalayan glaciers have a far-reaching impact on the water resources of India? **(2020)**

Q3. “The Himalayas are highly prone to landslides.” Discuss the causes and suggest suitable measures of mitigation. **(2016)**

Districts as Export Hubs

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Source: PIB

Why in News?

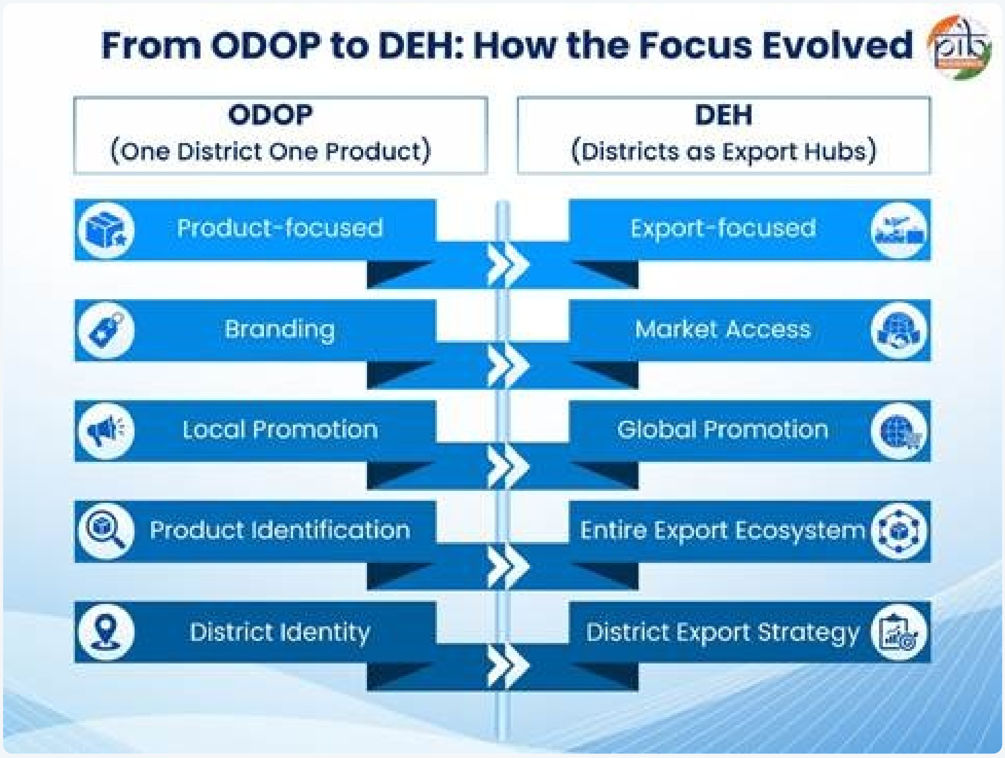
The Government has highlighted the role of the **Districts as Export Hubs (DEH) Initiative** in making India's export growth more inclusive by connecting local products and producers with international markets. The initiative aims to transform every district into an **export planning unit** by identifying products and services with global potential.

What are the Key Facts About Districts as Export Hubs Initiative?

- **Objective:** The **Districts as Export Hubs (DEH) Initiative** aims to utilise the unique strengths, resources, and products of every district to enhance their export potential and integrate local economies with global markets.
- **District as an Export Unit:** Unlike traditional approaches that focus mainly on production, DEH treats each district as a **unit of export planning** , helping local enterprises improve competitiveness, access international markets, and contribute to India's export growth.
- **Alignment with National Vision:** The initiative supports the objectives of **Aatmanirbhar Bharat** and **Vocal for Local** by promoting local products, strengthening MSMEs, and creating employment opportunities at the grassroots level.
- **Expansion through DEH:** The story of DEH begins with the One District One Product (ODOP) programme. The **Department of Commerce, through the Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) , expanded the ODOP approach into the DEH framework** by shifting focus from product promotion to a broader **export ecosystem development model** .
- **Coverage:** As of **January 2026** , the DEH initiative covers **more than 770 districts across India** , integrating district-level strengths with national export planning.

One District One Product (ODOP)

- **About:** The One District One Product (ODOP) scheme is a flagship programme of the Ministry of Commerce and Industry, implemented through the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) with support from Invest India.
  - Inspired by Japan's "One Village One Product" model, ODOP identifies, brands, and promotes one distinctive product from each district. As of 2025, it covers 1,102 products across 761 districts, including agriculture, handicrafts, textiles, and food items.
- **Objective:** The scheme aims to transform local specialities into global brands by supporting artisans, farmers, and small enterprises, while preserving India's cultural heritage and traditional skills.
  - Launched in Uttar Pradesh in 2018, starting with Moradabad's brassware, the initiative helped revive traditional crafts such as chikankari embroidery, pottery, carpets, leather goods and brassware.



Nature of the DEH Framework

- **Convergence-Based Approach:** DEH is not a separate funding scheme but a **convergence framework** that utilises existing central and state government schemes to address district-specific export challenges.
- **Export Ecosystem Development:** The initiative focuses on improving **manufacturing capacity, export readiness, logistics, quality standards, and market access** to enhance district-level competitiveness.
- **Grassroots Economic Development:** By supporting local industries, agricultural products, handicrafts, and MSMEs, DEH promotes **employment generation and inclusive economic growth** .

Institutional Architecture of DEH

- **Role of Department of Commerce and DGFT:** The **Department of Commerce** provides overall policy direction, while the **Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT)** manages implementation, stakeholder coordination, and monitoring of the initiative.
- **State-Level Mechanism: State Export Promotion Committees (SEPCs)** guide implementation at the state level and ensure coordination among different government departments.
- **District-Level Mechanism: District Export Promotion Committees (DEPCs)** identify export opportunities, address local challenges, and coordinate with exporters, industries, and stakeholders.
  - As of **March 2026** , draft **DEAPs have been prepared for 590 districts** , of which **249 have been formally adopted** by respective DEPCs.
- **Focused Approach for DEH Implementation** : From **1st June 2026** , the Government adopted an outcome-oriented and focused approach to accelerate the implementation of the **Districts as Export Hubs Initiative** .
  - **Coverage and Support:** The first phase covers districts across **27 States and Union Territories** with support from **24 DGFT Regional Authorities and 11 partner agencies** .
  - **Key Outcomes:** The initiative focuses on measurable outcomes such as increasing **new exporter registrations, expanding district export value, leveraging GI products, strengthening MSME clusters, and improving convergence of existing central and state schemes** .

Building District-Level Export Ecosystems

- **Identification of Export Potential Products:** DEH identifies district-specific products and services with export potential, including **GI-tagged products , agricultural clusters, handicrafts, engineering goods, and toy clusters** .
- **Ensuring Global Quality Standards:** DEH supports local producers by creating awareness and building capacity regarding **international quality standards, testing facilities, packaging, branding, and certification requirements** .
  - These interventions help district products meet global compliance requirements and improve export competitiveness.
- **Promoting Digital Export Opportunities:** DEH promotes digital access and e-commerce-based exports by connecting MSMEs and local producers with e-commerce platforms.
  - These partnerships provide cost-effective logistics solutions and help small businesses overcome challenges related to freight costs and market access.
  - **Dak Ghar Niryat Kendras** provide low-cost postal export facilities for documentation, packaging, and small export consignments.
- **Capacity Building and Export Awareness:** DGFT Regional Authorities, district administrations, and partner organisations conduct training programmes on **export procedures, logistics planning, packaging standards, and regulatory compliance** .
- **Fostering Grassroot Initiatives for Export Development:** The **DGFT has partnered with EXIM Bank** under the **Grassroots Initiatives for Development (GRID) programme** to strengthen export ecosystems in selected districts.
  - **Selected Districts:** Six districts— **Anantapur, Raipur, Solan, Tiruppur, Kanpur and Kolhapur** — have been selected under GRID to identify **sector-specific challenges, support potential beneficiaries and develop district-specific interventions** for enhancing **export competitiveness** .

Conclusion

The **Districts as Export Hubs Initiative** represents a shift from a concentrated export model to a **district-driven export ecosystem** . By identifying local strengths, strengthening MSMEs, improving export readiness and connecting producers with global markets, DEH is transforming local economies into engines of trade and employment. As India moves towards the ambition of **US$1 trillion exports** , empowering districts will be crucial for achieving inclusive, balanced and globally competitive economic growth.

Drishti Mains Question

The Districts as Export Hubs Initiative aims to decentralise India's export growth by leveraging local strengths and connecting districts with global markets. Discuss.

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What is the Districts as Export Hubs (DEH) Initiative?
DEH is an initiative to transform districts into centres of export planning by identifying local products and connecting producers with international markets.

2. Which organisation implements the DEH Initiative?
The initiative is implemented by the **Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT)** under the Department of Commerce.

3. Is DEH a separate funding scheme?
No, DEH is a convergence framework that uses existing Central and State schemes to promote exports.

4. What is the relation between ODOP and DEH?
ODOP focuses on promoting one district-specific product, while DEH expands this approach into a comprehensive export ecosystem.

5. What are District Export Action Plans (DEAPs)?
DEAPs are district-level plans identifying export products, infrastructure needs, challenges and interventions required for export promotion.

[Watch Video on YouTube: ▶ **https://www.youtube.com/embed/IB8EIBnHGj0]**

UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Mains

Q. Can the strategy of regional-resource based manufacturing help in promoting employment in India? **(2019)**

Q. What are the main bottlenecks in upstream and downstream process of marketing of agricultural products in India? **(2022)**

Khagantak-243 Long Range Glide Bomb

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Source: TOI

The **Indian Air Force (IAF)** successfully conducted the test drop of the indigenous **Khagantak-243 Long Range Glide Bomb (LRGB)** , marking a significant advancement in India's precision strike capabilities and defence self-reliance.

- **Indigenous Development:** The weapon has been developed by **Nagpur-based start-up JSR Dynamics Pvt Ltd** in collaboration with **Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL)** under the **Development-cum-Production Partner (DcPP) model** , highlighting public-private participation in defence manufacturing.
- **Technical Features:** Khagantak-243 is a 300 kg-class Long Range Glide Bomb equipped with a Mk-81 general-purpose blast fragmentation warhead containing around 125 kg explosive fill. It uses **swivel-type glide wings and aft control surfaces** to achieve a **glide ratio of more than 12** .
- **Range and Capability:** The glide bomb can strike targets at a distance of **144–180 km** when released from an altitude of around **12 km at Mach 0.8** , allowing fighter aircraft to engage targets without entering hostile air defence zones.
- **Aircraft Integration:** The weapon was initially tested from the **Su-30MKI fighter aircraft at Pokhran** and is planned for integration with platforms such as the **MiG-29K and Mirage-2000** .
- **Glide Bomb Technology:** Unlike cruise missiles, glide bombs **do not have an onboard propulsion system** . They use aerodynamic lift generated by wings to extend their range after release, making them a **cost-effective precision weapon system** .
- **Operational Significance:** Khagantak-243 will enhance the IAF's ability to conduct **long-range precision strikes** against targets such as **enemy runways, hardened shelters and command centres** while reducing risks to aircraft.
  - The Khagantak series also includes heavier variants such as **Khagantak-306 and Khagantak-225** , designed for longer-range strike capabilities.
- **Strategic Importance:** The induction of indigenous glide bombs will reduce dependence on imported precision munitions and strengthen India's goal of **Aatmanirbhar Bharat in defence manufacturing** .

Read More: **Long-Range Glide Bomb 'Gaurav'**

Consensus on Defining Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS)

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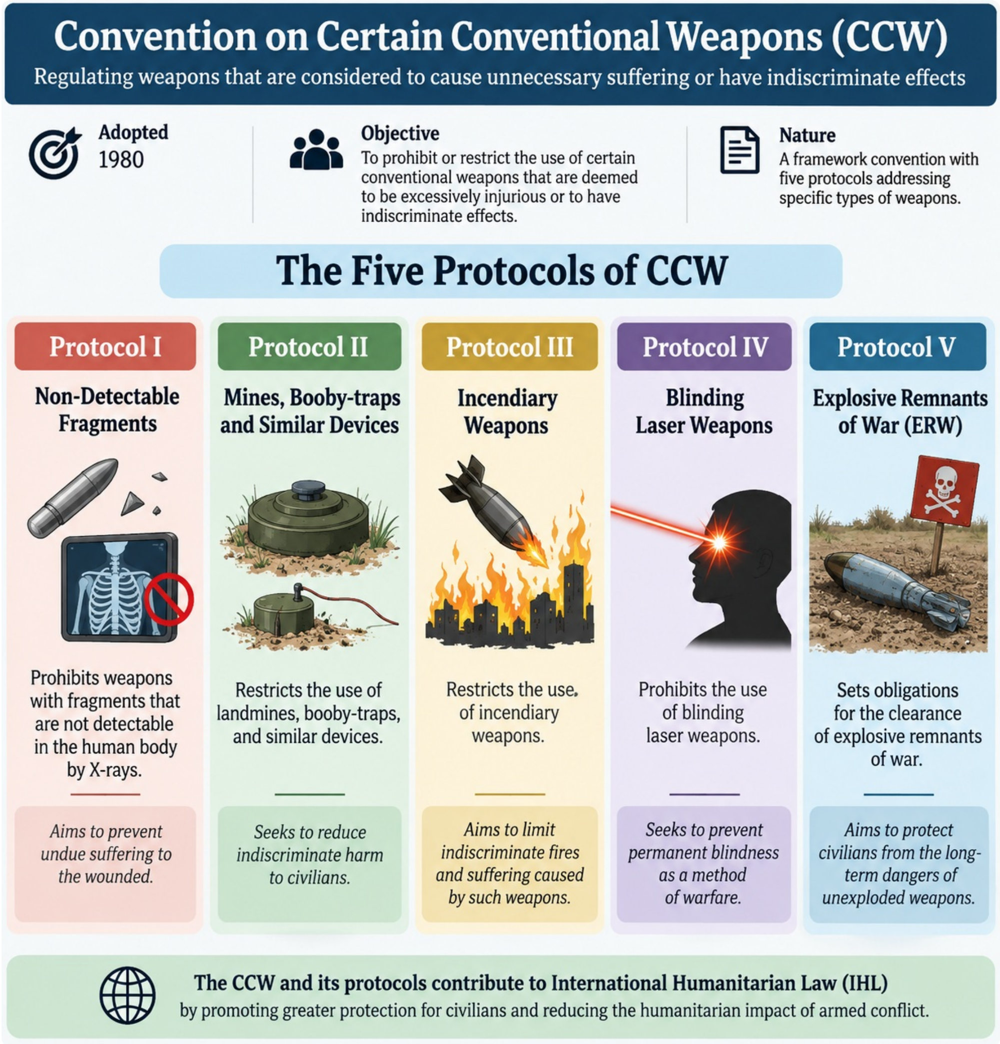
Source:TH

128 countries reached a consensus in Geneva under the **UN Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW)** on a text defining **Lethal Autonomous Weapons Systems (LAWS)** , or **“killer robots.”** The **non-binding agreement** marks an important step towards developing **international regulations or a future treaty** on autonomous weapons.

- **Defining "Killer Robots":** Autonomous military systems capable of **detecting, selecting and engaging targets based on pre-programmed parameters without meaningful human intervention or approval for each individual attack** .
- **Ethical and Humanitarian Imperatives:** The **International Committee of the Red Cross (ICRC)** emphasized that unregulated deployment of autonomous weapons violates fundamental tenets of **International Humanitarian Law (IHL)** , creating profound **ethical, legal, and accountability vacuums** on the battlefield.
- **Geopolitical Divide on Binding Norms:**
  - **Opponents of a legally binding ban/treaty:** Major powers including the **United States, Russia, India, and Israel** oppose restrictive treaties, favoring non-binding codes of conduct or relying on existing laws of armed conflict.
  - **Proponents of strict regulation:** A coalition led by **Brazil, Ireland, and Norway** is pushing for a mandatory, legally binding instrument to restrict autonomous targeting.
- **Concerns Over Text Dilution:** Watchdogs such as the **Stop Killer Robots** coalition have criticized the consensus text for being substantially **watered down** , arguing that core **protections for civilian population** s and strict operational limits were weakened to accommodate major military powers.

Convention on Certain Conventional Weapons (CCW)

- **About:** Adopted in Geneva in **1980 and entering into force in 1983,** the CCW (also known as **the Inhumane Weapons Convention**) is a UN framework treaty.
  - It seeks to prohibit or **restrict the use of conventional weapons considered to cause unnecessary suffering** to combatants or indiscriminate harm to civilians.
- **Structure:** The treaty consists of a framework convention containing general **provisions and five annexed protocols containing specific prohibitions** .
  - Its flexible structure allows new weapons and emerging technologies to be addressed by adding new protocols.
- **India’s Position:** India is a state party to the CCW and actively participates in the **Group of Governmental Experts (GGE) discussions on LAWS** , favoring discussions within this existing framework rather than creating separate parallel forums.



Read more: Rise of Autonomous Weapons: Challenges and Opportunities

Striped Hyenas

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Source: TH

The conservation of the **striped hyena** has gained attention due to **limited population data, conservation challenges** , and the need for a coordinated national conservation strategy.

Striped Hyena

- **About:** The **striped hyena (** ***Hyaena hyaena*** **)** is a member of the ***Hyaenidae family*** and **one of the three true hyena species,** along with the **brown hyena** and **spotted hyena.** However, the hyena family (Hyaenidae) also includes the **aardwolf.**

  - It is **smaller and less social** compared to the widely known spotted hyena and is primarily a **nocturnal scavenger** .
- **Species Status and Distribution:** The **striped hyena** is found across parts of Asia and Africa. Global estimates suggest around **5,000–14,000 striped hyenas** , with approximately **1,000–3,000 individuals in India** . India does not currently have a comprehensive official census for the species.
- **Ecological Role as a Scavenger:** Striped hyenas **act as natural cleaners of ecosystems by consuming carrion and removing decaying animal remains** . Their scavenging behaviour supports ecosystem health by preventing accumulation of organic waste.
- **Protection Status:**
  - **IUCN Red List:** Near Threatened.
  - **Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972: Schedule I**
- **Need for a National Conservation Framework:** Conservation efforts remain fragmented, with regional initiatives in states such as **West Bengal and Tamil Nadu** . A coordinated National Action Plan can integrate research, funding and conservation initiatives across regions.
- **Threats:** Negative cultural beliefs and superstitions surrounding hyenas contribute to persecution, human-wildlife conflict, and challenges in their conservation.
- **Awareness and Community Participation:** Community engagement, awareness campaigns and educational initiatives can promote scientific understanding of striped hyenas and encourage their protection.

Read More: Conservation Breeding in Indira Gandhi Zoological Park (IGZP)